

Professional doctors

From the 9th century onward, Arabic medical texts, which incorporated the work of ancient Greek and Roman physicians, became available in translation in Western Europe. Among these was the work of Greek medical pioneer Hippocrates, who had developed a theory of the four humors around 400 BCE. According to his theory, imbalances in the body in the levels of blood, phlegm, and black and yellow bile caused disease, and restoring their equilibrium would cure the illness.

Hippocrates' theory laid the basis for formal medieval training, and around 1075 a medical school was founded at Salerno in southern Italy. The process of forming a trained workforce began. These new doctors became protective of their authority and status and sought to squeeze out traditional practitioners: as early as 1140 King Roger of Sicily required healers and physicians to have an official license. However, it was only the rich who could afford to consult licensed doctors. Despite advances in education, popular medicine and the belief in its magical properties were deep-rooted and hard to stamp out.

Saintly cures

As well as science or magic, people sometimes looked to religious methods to prevent or cure illness. In the 8th–9th centuries, the Frankish king Charlemagne himself was said to own a relic made up of two crystal hemispheres containing portions of the True Cross and the hair of the Virgin Mary for protection from disease and



◀ Showing the way

A pharmacist gathers herbs in this illustration from the *Tacuinum Sanitatis*, an 11th-century herbal and manual for healthy living. Herbs played a key role in popular medicine, and as their use had a clear physical effect, it met the clergy's general approval.

danger. Christian beliefs also fed into explanations of how particular methods worked; in the mid-12th century, for example,

the abbess Hildegard of Bingen wrote that the Devil hated gemstones—widely believed to have curative properties—because they reminded him of the City of God. In such an environment, where believers from all levels of society routinely prayed to saints for cures—for example, to Apollonia, whose jaw, the story went, had been broken by her Roman tormentors, and who became the patron saint of toothache sufferers—there was a fine line between acceptable Christian practices and medical magic.

Folk medicine

The poor had no recourse to trained doctors. Instead, they depended on folk healers, who offered herbal cures for a range of ills from childbirth pains to boils and toothache.

Folk medical practices included the use of sympathetic magic, which meant that the healer found something similar to the ailment in nature and attempted to banish the disease with it. For

▼ Curing sore eyes

This page from an 11th-century English herbal shows the entries for Hart's clover and chamomile. The text recommends making them into a paste and smearing it on the eyelids as a remedy for sore eyes.



“What about those ... who sing charms over the sick, children, and animals? Surely they do not sin mortally?”